ONCE UPON A TIME, Amrita Pillai (*name changed*) would keep Friday nights for hooking up with her various digital chat buddies. This was five years ago when Pillai was 29 and still a mid-career professional in the investment banking sector. Now, at the age of 34, Mumbai-based Pillai has a lot more commitments that occupy all her time, including her once-favourite Friday night. She is responsible for two young interns, has double the work load, housing loans to repay, a longer commute to work ever since she shifted from the local train to driving her own car. Not to mention an ageing mother recovering from endometrial cancer. "Where is the time for pleasure?" she asks. "When there is time on hand, all I want to do is sleep and be alone. Dating, sex, masturbation, romance... seem more work than fun now." When she has had the time to date, the men, she says, have been hopeless failures. "The people I meet are also tired. They are only interested in themselves and don't put in the effort to learn about a woman's body. It's a double whammy—there's less time for sex and when there is time, the sex is bad," says Pillai.

The INDIA TODAY Sex Survey 2023 reflects this precise pleasure gap—both between people and sex, as well as between partners. On the one hand, a majority of the respondents—57 per cent, or more than half—seem to want more sex than they are getting, indicating that there is most definitely a need for pleasure. This finding is corroborated by another—that the number of people who are unhappy with their sex lives today is four times as high as it was just five years ago. In 2018, only 5.5 per cent of the respondents said they felt unsatisfied with their sex lives. This has increased to 19 per cent today. Even allowing for sampling issues, a worrying high. Experts say stress and lifestyle are the chief villains causing dissatisfaction in rela-



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